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Liselotte Odgaard

Introduction

As a Chinese official remarked during an interview at the Central Party School of the Communist Party of China in Beijing on November 2, 2004, "The United States likes to box, whereas China likes shadow boxing." This statement pinpoints the fundamental difference between the American and Chinese security policies. Washington usually conducts a relatively straightforward policy of implementing measures of pre-emption, unilateralism and hegemony assisted by its alliance system with the purpose of spreading liberal democracy and the rule of law. The policy is dominated by the belief that America's economic and military superiority gives Washington the necessary means to impose its will upon other states. The advantage of the U.S. policies is that its means and purpose are clear. Washington makes no secret of its intention to discard the old principles and practices of the Cold War based on a belief in the moral superiority of its own ideals of state conduct. Throughout the 1990s, the United States experimented with a policy of persuasion when it

was hoped that the liberal model of state and society was sufficient enough to convince the world that the U.S. version of international order was the only attractive alternative left following the discrediting of communism with the collapse of the Soviet Union. The returns on this accommodating policy proved to be low because beyond the Western hemisphere, numerous states refused to buy into Washington's ideas of how states ought to manage political authority to produce the greatest benefits for the largest number of people. In particular, the widespread authoritarian-style governments were less than thrilled with the prospects of being subjected to popular demands that might not only bring down the incumbent, but also engender the disintegration of states still struggling to create coherent nations whose loyalty was firmly directed towards the state apparatus.

Washington did not adjust its policies so as to take into account the fact that the majority of states face conditions vastly different from the United States. Their unique cultural heritages and their perceptions of the common good of the people cannot be easily accommodated by the liberal model of state and society as perceived by the United States. Instead, spurred on by the terrorist attacks on the Pentagon and the World Trade Center, the United States saw a historic chance to set its mark on the structures and principles of global order. The United States opted for a policy of imposition with the purpose of revising the existing international order in correspondence with American interests and values. Of course, Washington cannot completely ignore the demands and interests of other states; mostly it only takes them into account as it is necessary to achieve the long-term goal of sustaining American pre-eminence and establishing an international order based on the American definitions of right and wrong state conduct. For example, it may involve strengthening ties

with certain allies such as Pakistan, which seldom fulfils the American criteria for proper state conduct in the interim, even if Washington does not plan to rely on these allies in the long term. The downside to Washington's policy is the opposition that it provoked by the arrogance of its strategy of imposition. Nevertheless, most states find that the devil they know is the safest bet even though they have to accept measures that, at times, are at odds with their interests. The principal advantage of supporting Washington's policy is the security guarantees offered by the United States, which protect them against what they perceive as the greater evil, namely an order dominated by a rising China.

China is the shadow boxer, implying that its strategies and intentions are never quite obvious to its surrounding neighbours. That is perhaps the principal reason for the aversion to the emergence of a Sino-centric order, the fear of the unknown. Beijing conducts an unpredictable policy that involves the implementation of cooperative security, unilateralism and multipolarity assisted by its adherence to the United Nations (U.N.) system, which was heavily shaped by the Cold War. The purpose is apparently to gradually spread its model of hierarchy and reunification of the Chinese motherland. Or is it? That question remains unanswered and is the cause of the uncertainty as to what goals and intentions lie behind Chinese foreign policy. At the same time, China's advantage is precisely the indeterminable character of its policies since it gives Beijing a high level of flexibility, allowing China to swiftly adjust its goals and intentions according to the rapidly changing circumstances. This constant in Chinese foreign policy has been supplemented by a policy shift whereby, in addition to unilateral policy measures, there is an activist policy in multilateral institutions.

In the 1990s, China began experimenting with multilateral security dialogue and institutionalization of security cooperation in Southeast and Central Asia. International cooperation that goes beyond the stage of dialogue requires willingness to compromise, such as the shelving of the sovereignty question in the South China Sea in return for the opportunity to develop economic and security ties with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN). The main payoff for this new policy was that China established links with the U.S. allies and strategic partners, making inroads into the American alliance system by offering alternative benefits. In a sense, China overtook the U.S. policy of persuasion of the 1990s, presumably out of necessity, since China's economic and military capabilities remain far too modest to pursue a policy of imposition. China makes considerable efforts to convince the Southeast Asian region of its peaceful intentions, embedding its foreign policy in the Cold War principles of the U.N. system of absolute sovereignty, effective control and respect for the authority of the U.N. Security Council. An additional benefit of this policy is that the alleged immorality of U.S. state conduct is exposed. To some extent it works. In very few years, China has obtained numerous strategic partners except in its immediate Northeast Asian neighbourhood where the U.S. alliance system also has its strongest foothold.

Meanwhile, the flaws in China's foreign policy concept emerge most clearly in this sub-region because it insists that Taiwan remains under the jurisdiction of mainland China and because it has failed to fit Japan into its version of international order. Despite all the progress China has made in presenting itself as a responsible great power, it continues to rely on unilateralism, although mainly in the form of a passive military build-up and continued reservations towards stable

alliances. However, by doing so, Beijing reveals that its cooperative foreign policy and advocacy of the U.N. system remains experimental and may be withdrawn at a later date when China has sufficient economic and military capabilities to impose a Sino-centric order. The drawback to Beijing's policy is its preferred two-pronged strategy, which fails to convince neighbouring states that China's rise will remain peaceful. Support for the Chinese version of international order is hence likely to involve continued reservations. Most Asia-Pacific states are likely to continue relying on the United States for security guarantees, predominantly serving to protect them against China's growing power. Shadow boxing may permit the expansion of Chinese political influence beyond that justified by its economic and military capabilities. However, it does not produce the loyal allies and partners that could help China win the contest for influence on international order.

The U.S. and China: Rivalry or Cooperation?

The last decade has seen very little progress in the direction of stable Sino-American power balancing. The Sino-American policies in the Asia-Pacific region indicate that instead of focusing on areas of compromise, the United States and China adhere to competing concepts of regional order. Washington advocates an order predominantly based on military instruments as opposed to Beijing's preference for an order founded in the instruments of diplomacy. This difference means that the United States concentrates on activities such as the reorganization of its military presence to increase the credibility of flexible response and preventive first-use, the involvement of American armed forces in the domestic security policies of other states, as well as the maintenance of its Cold War alliance system as the basis of permanent security arrangements in

the Asia-Pacific. For its part, China increasingly focuses on the forging of compromises with states that are at least partially supportive of Chinese interim demands for respect for the absolute sovereignty of states, acceptance of political authorities with a proven record of control over geographically delimited territories and people, and institutionalized security arrangements founded in the U.N. system of the Cold War. These Chinese demands reflect the weaker power's resolution to postpone any permanent revision of security arrangements in the Asia-Pacific until Beijing is strong enough to exercise influence on a par with Washington.

With such conflicting views on regional order, the United States and China leave considerable responsibility for the maintenance of stability to middle powers such as the ASEAN member states, Russia, South Korea and India that have sufficient economic and military capacities to remain partially independent of great power policies, and at the same time neither the United States nor China can afford to ignore them. Seen from the perspectives of these middle powers, it is not desirable that Washington or Beijing dominates Asia-Pacific security. First, because neither of them provides an altogether attractive alternative, but second and perhaps even more importantly, the middle powers have much influence when the two powers compete for dominance by offering diverse versions of regional order instead of one coherent system of order. In the current environment, the middle powers are left with extraordinary responsibilities for preserving the power balance between the United States and China. However, it remains to be seen whether their efforts will result in the Sino-American agreement on permanent security arrangements for the Asia-Pacific.

Stable instability in Asia-Pacific security

The proliferation in strategic partnerships and ad hoc collaboration with numerous powers reflect China's success in postponing the settlement of a stable order for the Asia-Pacific as a whole. But the middle powers are reluctant to choose between the two powers. Neither do they have to take side with either one of them because of the inability of the United States and China to agree on fundamental rules of state conduct. For Washington, there seems to be two alternative ways of preserving the U.S. pre-eminence. One solution would be to accommodate Chinese demands for regional order and renounce on some of the principles of the American version of regional order. Washington's prioritization of building up the force postures of its Northeast Asian ally Japan and its strategic partner Taiwan provokes Beijing, since mainland China maintains its claim to jurisdiction over Taiwan and the Sino-Japanese enmity prevails. A Sino-American agreement based on an order of coexistence requires the United States to limit its aggressive pursuit of consolidating its alliance system. The strengthening of the U.S. military cooperation with China's adversaries encourages Beijing to increase its defence expenditures. It may be due to this U.S. policy that Beijing continues to rely on a passive form of unilateralism instead of making a whole-hearted commitment to a cooperative foreign policy based on the common interests of both countries.

Perhaps more importantly, Washington's pursuit of the spread of liberal democracy and the rule of law is not acceptable to China. Even if Washington tends to prioritize stability before democracy and human rights, it does pursue the latter goals when a convenient occasion appears. This was the case with the 2005 Andijon killings in Uzbekistan, or when the U.S. national security interests are

considered to be threatened as shown in the 2001 intervention in Afghanistan. At the end of the day, the United States is awaiting a democratization of mainland China itself because that would imply the defeat of Beijing's version of regional order. These plans constitute the major long-term threat in the eyes of Beijing because the communist regime cannot risk buying into a U.S. scheme of regional order that involves its own fall. If China had an alternative model of domestic political authority appealing to neighbouring states, the Sino-American disagreement on the issue of legitimacy might ironically have been minimized. Washington would then have realized the infeasibility of trying to spread liberal democracy and the rule of law in the Chinese part of the world, just as the United States learned to accommodate the Soviet Union during the Cold War. The political philosophy of Confucianism, which is based on collective and hierarchical principles, has occasionally been suggested as a possible basis for constructing an alternative model of state-society relations if translated into workable political arrangements. However, it remains to be seen if such a process is set in motion. So far, Confucianism has predominantly been used as a pretext to fend off demands for liberal political reform rather than as a basis for constructing a viable model of domestic legitimacy. And the majority of China's neighbours perceive the Chinese ideas of historical sovereignty and hierarchy as major drawbacks to a Sino-centric order.

Since China cannot come up with a viable alternative to the U.S. version of domestic order, its best bet is to advocate the preservation of the U.N. system of the Cold War. It allows for the prevalence of heterogeneous political systems due to its principles of absolute sovereignty and non-intervention in the domestic affairs of other

states. This is a negative solution in that it serves to prevent the United States from enforcing its own principles of domestic conduct without suggesting viable alternatives. This is a weakness in China's proposal which provides Washington with an outstanding chance to invest Asia-Pacific order with its own values of state-society relations. The prospects of a compromise between the United States and China that might allow for power balancing founded in coexistence hence look bleak.

The Advantages and Disadvantages of Stable Instability in the Twentieth-first Century

Will this type of unstable order stay with us for so long that this is the kind of order we will have in the twenty-first century? If so, its principal characteristics are already known: the absence of binding alliance commitments, a highly unpredictable international environment but also a considerable freedom of action allowing for swift foreign policy adjustments. This kind of prolonged interim order has advantages as well as drawbacks. For the United States, the advantage of the current order is that it allows Washington to pursue its economic interests almost wherever it wants. China's embrace of market economic structures that are so central to the U.S. demands for regional order is hence a vast **improvement** compared with the **communist** alternative adopted by the Eastern bloc during the Cold War. Moreover, the United States has an outstanding chance of promoting its version of domestic political order, not only because China has not suggested an alternative, but also because the strengthening of the American alliance system serves to enhance the regional democracies forming the core of the system. The costs of maintaining the current order will be much higher if the United States completely dominates the Asia-Pacific region. In particular, the

critical voice of the secondary powers carries much weight in Washington because China provides them an alternative strategic partnership. Russia's change of policy in the 1990s has been most remarkable. In the early 1990s, Moscow sided with the United States. However, since the late 1990s, disappointment about the returns from this partnership and concern about the consequences of U.S. policies on legitimacy caused Russia to align with China. Arguably, Moscow's change in priorities has encouraged the United States to compromise its anti-WMD principles to accommodate the equally important Indian political establishment in order to ensure that India gravitates towards the United States rather than China. Similarly, ASEAN's rapprochement with China implies that the United States has to conduct a relatively conciliatory policy towards the Southeast Asian states. For example, one reason that Washington had to retreat from its demand to send troops to assist patrolling the Malacca Strait is arguably that the Chinese supported a request from Indonesia and Malaysia to remain in control of the strait.

Nevertheless, ultimately the United States benefits substantially from the current order since it remains the only dominant power in the Asia-Pacific. For example, it could afford to stay away from the ASEAN Regional Forum's summit in 2005, making Beijing subsequently follow suit. This demonstrated that Washington remains the first among equals. And as much as Beijing attempts to poach on U.S. alliances and strategic partnerships, the majority of Asia-Pacific states continue to rely on Washington for the most vital means of survival, namely security guarantees, which Beijing cannot provide. Most Asia-Pacific states would not want to rely on Beijing even if China had the military capabilities to do so since,

if forced to choose, they would opt for a Pax Americana rather than a Sino-centric order. This characterizes the priorities of the majority of ASEAN member states, South Korea and India and of course states such as Taiwan, Japan, Australia and New Zealand that are at the core of the U.S. alliance system. Russia relies on its own extensive military capabilities instead. Ideally, Washington would prefer to implement its version of regional order in its totality, and its ongoing efforts to contain China point to the goal of achieving regional hegemony. Current conditions are, nevertheless, sufficiently satisfactory for the United States to profit substantially from the present regional order, and since Washington has to take into account the views of the secondary powers, US policies will most likely contribute to its maintenance.

The Chinese foreign policy also seems to sit well with a high level of unpredictability and a low level of commitment, which allows Beijing to give an enigmatic impression of its strategies and goals. To some extent, this has been a deliberate Chinese strategy since the late 1970s, designed to safeguard it against pressures from superior powers at odds with Chinese interests. Although, after Secretary of State Henry Kissinger visited Beijing in 1971, the Asia-Pacific was often described as tripolar, the Chinese did not in any serious way challenge the status which the United States and the Soviet Union enjoyed during the Cold War. It seems more reasonable to describe China during the later years of the Cold War as a middle power which was strong enough to avoid subservience to any great power's demands and capable of conducting a foreign policy founded in alternating gravitation towards the United States and the Soviet Union. First, China's nuclear capability combined with substantial low-technological conventional capabilities allowed this policy to be implemented. In addition, China's willingness to use force against

foreign encroachment of the territorial integrity of what was defined as the Chinese motherland was well proven. Second, a significant pragmatic element pervaded Chinese foreign policy thinking, as implied by its willingness to side with the liberal as well as the communist blocs. Third, China based its foreign policy decisions firmly on an estimate of which partnership would result in the highest returns for China's national interests. Its foreign policy profile points to the existence of an alternative programme for international order to that of the United States and the Soviet Union. China was presented as a developing state aiming for peaceful coexistence, a new economic world order and defiance of alliances. In contrast to the great powers, China was not in a position to export its development model to other countries to any significant extent. The alternative political framework remained a rhetorical device designed to highlight China's foreign policy independence since Beijing did not command sufficient influence to have an impact on the fundamental principles of international order. China's principal gain was the considerable strategic, economic and political benefits that it was able to extract by its foreign policy. It did, however, not contribute to or alter the political framework used by the United States and the Soviet Union for the management of international order.

China's influence in the international realm has been out of proportion to its actual economic and military capabilities since then. One explanation is its skilful manoeuvring between the United States and the Soviet Union. They were not at ease with a state that refused to take sides, and opted for a high level of freedom of action that enabled it to adjust quickly to changes in the bipolar balancing pattern. If interpreted in this way, the present order is not intermediate, but has already been adjusted to serve Chinese interests. The difference between the present order and that of the

Cold War is, however, that China no longer acts as a middle power alternating between alliances. Instead, the pattern of Chinese foreign policy in the Asia-Pacific resembles that of a dominant power in spe. It is difficult to utilize this potential under conditions of high unpredictability, as indicated by its calls for a stable international environment allowing it to concentrate on economic development. The costs of constant foreign policy adjustments are high in a situation where China prefers to direct the majority of resources towards the economic sector. But if the United States remains determined to establish a Pax Americana, China is left with few choices but to continue its present foreign policy.